PARTICIPANT HANDOUT | LESSON 12

# 1 Corinthians Part 4

*Resurrection Hope*

**BIG IDEA** Christ's bodily resurrection guarantees the resurrection of his people and makes steadfast service worthwhile.

**Series location:** Lesson 12 of 24 | 1 Corinthians 15-16

**Primary texts:** 1 Corinthians 15:1-8, 12-28, 35-58; 16:13-14

**Series question:** What problem is Paul addressing, and how does the gospel answer it?

## Follow Paul's argument

| PASSAGE | MOVEMENT |
|---|---|
| 15:1-11 | The gospel Paul received and passed on: Christ died, was buried, was raised, and appeared. |
| 15:12-19 | If Christ was not raised, preaching and faith are empty, sin still condemns, and the dead have perished. |
| 15:20-28 | Christ is the firstfruits; his people will be raised, and death will be destroyed. |
| 15:29-34 | Paul exposes the inconsistency of resurrection-denying belief and practice. |
| 15:35-49 | God raises a body that is continuous with the present body yet gloriously transformed. |
| 15:50-58 | The dead are raised, the living are changed, and victory over death makes steadfast work worthwhile. |
| 16:1-24 | Resurrection hope becomes generosity, faithful service, courage, strength, and love. |

## The gospel received and passed on

| WHAT HAPPENED | WHY IT MATTERS |
|---|---|
| Christ died for our sins | His death addresses guilt within God's saving purpose. |
| He was buried | Jesus truly died. |
| He was raised on the third day | God acted bodily and decisively. |
| He appeared to witnesses | Christian faith rests on apostolic testimony about an event in history. |

## If Christ was not raised

Preaching is empty. Faith is futile. The apostles misrepresent God. Believers remain in their sins. Those who died in Christ have perished. Christian hope reaches no farther than this life. Paul's conclusion is blunt: remove the resurrection and the Christian gospel collapses.

## But Christ has indeed been raised

Christ is the firstfruits of the resurrection harvest. His resurrection is both the beginning and the guarantee: those who belong to him will be raised at his coming, every hostile power will be defeated, and the last enemy - death - will be destroyed.

## The resurrection body

| SOWN | RAISED | PROMISE |
|---|---|---|
| Perishable | Imperishable | No decay or death |
| In dishonor | In glory | Restored to God's intended splendor |
| In weakness | In power | Freed from mortal frailty |
| A natural body | A spiritual body | Embodied life transformed and empowered by the Spirit |
| Bearing Adam's image | Bearing Christ's image | Conformed to the risen Lord |

Spiritual body does not mean an immaterial ghost. Paul means a real body fitted for imperishable life under the power of God's Spirit. 'Flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom' means mortal humanity cannot enter God's final kingdom unchanged.

**THEREFORE** Because Christ has won the victory, stand firm, let nothing move you, and give yourselves fully to the work of the Lord. Your labor in the Lord is not in vain (15:57-58).

## The Gospel Then and Now

**Church claim then** Some Corinthians tried to keep Christian faith while denying the future bodily resurrection of believers.

**Church temptation now** We can reduce resurrection to a symbol, imagine salvation as escape from embodiment, or live as though present work ends at death.

**Gospel-shaped hope** Because Christ was bodily raised, believers await transformed embodied life and serve now with steadiness, generosity, courage, strength, and love.

## Discuss

1. Why is bodily resurrection essential to the gospel rather than a secondary belief?
2. How does Christ as firstfruits strengthen Christian hope?
3. What misunderstandings are corrected by the phrase 'spiritual body'?
4. Where are we tempted to think faithful work is pointless or wasted?
5. How should resurrection hope change the way our church serves now?

## For further study

**Related passages** Romans 8:18-25; Philippians 3:20-21; 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18; Revelation 21:1-5

**ECO connection** Essential Tenets II.B, the incarnation and bodily resurrection of Jesus Christ, and III.A, God's grace in Christ. eco-pres.org/constitution/

**CLASS RESOURCES AND UPCOMING LESSONS**
keithbreuer615.github.io/pauls-letters-class/



**BEFORE NEXT WEEK** Read 2 Corinthians 1-7. Mark where Paul connects suffering, weakness, comfort, integrity, reconciliation, and the power of God.